How a One-Year Course Became Memories for Life



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AFTER MY MBA IN FINANCE, I wanted to transition in my education to a non-profit kind of orientation. By then, I was already into films. In fact, my first film happened in the midst of my first year of work at GE Research in Bengaluru as a risk consultant working on statistical models, which I took up soon after my MBA. For six months, I juggled films and work before quitting my job to focus on the former.

In 2007, I was shooting for the Malayalam film *Kerala Varma Pazhassi Raja* and it was a long shoot during which I couldn't sign up for anything else. That's when I took up a one-year Postgraduate Diploma in Environmental Law at the National Law School of India University (NLSIU). It was a long-distance course with three or four classroom sessions. Plus you had to write a thesis. It was more a one-and-a-half-year course, including the time taken for the dissertation.

So in that way, my association with NLSIU was very critical. Environment was something close to me but I realised it is such a humongous space that probably the best way to start studying about it was through law. Because it kind of defines the very many parameters and outlooks in a much more concise way. In the scenario that you didn't do your BA LLB [Legum Baccalaureus], the PG diploma was a great way to understand not only how to break down legal language but more importantly get a 360-degree understanding of a particular sector.

The faculty was brilliant. They started with environmental ethics which really got me headlong into the subject. Those four-five days of classroom sessions were quite intense. We were just 15-20 of us and I'm still in touch with a couple of my course mates who are full-time environmental engineers. The only unfortunate part was that the long-distance course classes were held during the university vacation breaks, so we never really got to meet students of other courses. But since we had free access to the library, I spent a lot of research time there. I was obsessed about the course. I loved the canteen which served proper *ghar ka khaana*—simple *dal-rotis* and *sambhar*. The classroom sessions were very intense because they would pack a lot into the four-five days. We would be asked to prep and study beforehand. Hence, we wouldn't get breathing time. The sessions would be open to questions, discussions and conversations. I have very strong, happy memories of my time at NLSIU—*chai*, library, canteen food, a great cohort of people and a great faculty. That's what I would say.

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I really hold my NLSIU experience to extreme importance because it connected me to Samata, which is a tribal rights organisation where I found my mentor. In 2013, when I took a break from films, my experience at NLSIU propelled me to take a three-credit course in the US with New York University on Public Finance, Gender & Food Policy. The best part of the course at NLSIU was that it was very self-initiated, and so a lot of what I had studied there prepared me when I went to the US. I still have my notes from NLSIU and all the books which I had acquired. So, I hold my experience there as very precious. ■

*(As told to **Ajay Sukumaran**)*

Janakiraman is a National Award-winning actor and was part of the 2007 batch of Post Graduate Diploma in Environmental Law at NLSIU